Europe responds to Trump's Putin deal

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Presented by EFPIA By NICHOLAS VINOCUR with SEBASTIAN STARCEVIC and GERARDO FORTUNA GREETINGS. It's Nick Vinocur. Let's dive in. In today's Playbook:

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GREETINGS. It's Nick Vinocur. Let's dive in.

In today's Playbook:

— How many influencers are too many to cover the State of the Union?

— France wants Brussels to use a Google fine to lower EU budget contributions.

— Faces in the crowd: Vladimir Putin, Angèle, Donald Trump, Bärbel Bas, Volodymyr Zelenskyy, Kimberly Guilfoyle, Friedrich Merz, Alice Weidel, Sophie Dupin de Saint-Cyr, Tore O. Sandvik, Andy Burnham, Kata Tüttő, Norbert Röttgen and more …

On today's Brussels Playbook Podcast: Zoya and Ian unpack an exclusive poll showing that most Spaniards see Morocco as a threat — and why Ceuta will be on EU leaders' minds this week.

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A message from EFPIA: Investing in health pays back. For every €1 invested in innovative medicines, Europe gains €5.67 in economic, social and healthcare value. These benefits ripple far beyond the health system. In an increasingly competitive world, Europe cannot afford to separate its health from its economic and strategic ambitions.

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DRIVING THE DAY

SPLIT OVER UKRAINE WIDENS AHEAD OF U.S. MIDTERMS: European leaders are set to call for renewed pressure on Russia via sanctions and measures targeting Moscow's energy revenues when they gather in Brussels later this week, according to officials, statements from leaders and draft conclusions of the summit seen by POLITICO.

Transatlantic chasm: The chorus of leaders seeking to strangle Russian President Vladimir Putin's war economy, on the heels of the EU's largest-ever package of individual sanctions listings being approved in Luxembourg yesterday, shows a widening gulf between the two sides of the Atlantic ahead of U.S. midterm elections in November.

While Ukraine's European allies harden their tone, U.S. President Donald Trump is going the other way by announcing a deal with Russia on diesel. "There was a sense that the last few days ⋯ are like Oval Office Part 2," said an EU official, referring to the infamous February 2025 episode, in which Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy was humiliated at the White House.

Who's in? Heavyweight leaders including German Chancellor Friedrich Merz and Polish Prime Minister Donald Tusk are leading the charge ahead of a European Council starting Thursday, which will otherwise focus on the bloc's long-term budget, energy costs and EU enlargement plans. "Following Moscow's reckless attacks on Ukraine's civilian energy supply, we must tighten [sanctions] even further," Merz said.

Everyone but Washington: The tough line is also being echoed by Ukraine's allies outside the EU. Norway's Defense Minister Tore O. Sandvik told Laura Kayali that it's necessary to "close loopholes" in the sanctions, while U.K. Prime Minister Andy Burnham vowed to "maintain pressure on Russia through the toughest sanctions regime ever imposed," according to his spokesperson.

In private, EU officials say Trump's embrace of a diesel deal with Russia — as well as his verbal attacks on Zelenskyy and claims to have brokered an energy truce between Moscow and Kyiv — are mainly driven by political concerns ahead of the midterms. That's the "broadly held view," a senior EU official, granted anonymity to speak about the private mood, told Zoya Sheftalovich.

Zelenskyy's predicament: Trump's diesel move couldn't have come at a worse time for Ukrainians, as they brace for a bleak winter, and it has left Zelenskyy to weigh up just how angry he can afford to get , as Jamie Dettmer explains.

Wider view: Trump's Republican Party is at risk of losing control of Congress and the president, having promised during his 2024 campaign to bring gasoline prices under $2 per gallon, now hopes the release of an additional 4.8 million tons of Russian diesel onto global markets in coming months will push down prices.

But that's unlikely to work, argue EU officials and lawmakers. "This [deal] is purely an election-campaign measure by Donald Trump," Norbert Röttgen, deputy chair of the center-right CDU/CSU group in Germany's Bundestag, told Rixa Fürsen. "We have no influence over it and it will not change fuel prices in the United States."

The bottom line: While they lament the U.S. not joining forces with Europe to pressure Russia, EU leaders are holding their fire against Trump — lining up behind Kyiv and quietly hoping POTUS will switch gears after the midterm elections.

MEANWHILE, AT NATO HQ ⋯ Supreme Allied Commander Europe Gen. Alexus Grynkewich says the military alliance has a three-part blueprint to block, blunt and break any Russian attack — and will fight

back even if American forces are engaged elsewhere. Grynkewich laid out NATO's new "Theory of Victory" at the Warsaw Security Forum yesterday, Victor Jack reports .

BIG AND BREAKING

CEUTA'S LONG SHADOW: A majority of Spaniards believe that tensions between Spain and Morocco over Ceuta and Melilla could spiral into an armed conflict within the next decade, according to a POLITICO poll .

Read about that and more in Madrid Playbook, POLITICO's first Spanish-language Playbook, which launches today with the inside line on the personalities and power plays shaping Spanish politics. It'll be essential daily reading as the country prepares to head to the polls on Nov. 29. The inaugural edition will drop here shortly and you can sign up here for future editions.

SQUEEZING OUT STARLINK: French President Emmanuel Macron is urging Europe's top satellite players to forge an alliance to take on Elon Musk's Starlink .

AFD CHIEF TO JOIN STRASBOURG PLENARY: Alternative for Germany leader Alice Weidel will be in Strasbourg next Wednesday to set out "her perspectives on the future of European cooperation" at an event titled "Our New Deal for Europe," according to an email circulated among lawmakers seen by Max Griera. She'll appear alongside Europe of Sovereign Nations Chair René Aust and MEP Alexander Sell, president of the ESN foundation.

IN THE FIRING LINE: Donald Trump told reporters last night he's thinking about dismissing U.S. Ambassador to Greece Kimberly Guilfoyle following reports that she urged a Republican donor to pay off a six-figure credit card bill.

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SOCIAL MEDIA OVERLOAD

EXCLUSIVE — INFLUENCER OVERLOAD? European Commission President Ursula von der Leyen was all smiles for the selfies at her State of the Union speech last month. But behind the scenes, her social media chief thought it was all a bit much, two EU officials told Playbook's Sebastian Starcevic and Gerardo Fortuna.

Around 70 content creators descended on Strasbourg for the speech — far too many, according to Sophie Dupin de Saint-Cyr, von der Leyen's head of social media, who gave officials at the Commission's communications department a dressing-down at an internal meeting, the two officials said. They were granted anonymity to discuss the confidential meeting.

The sheer number of influencers was overwhelming and distracting for von der Leyen on one of her biggest days of the year, one official said Dupin de Saint-Cyr complained, adding that the president simply couldn't find time for them all. Another EU official said von der Leyen "was very displeased." Dupin de Saint-Cyr didn't respond to Playbook's request for comment.

Not so fast: The Commission disputed this account, saying von der Leyen "enjoyed the discussions so much that she stayed longer than planned to continue engaging with the young participants." The Commission declined to comment on the internal meeting.

Down with the kids? The spat comes as Brussels tries to crack the Gen Z code, using social media to reach younger Europeans and counter disinformation. Youth Commissioner Glenn Micallef has even hired influencers to advise on his comms.

An echo chamber? A third official questioned the value of inviting EU-focused influencers to major events when their followers are presumably already sold on Brussels.

Going offline: There are no influencers at this week's European Council, Mari Eccles reported. The EU's leaders, it seems, are sticking to their own generation.

20-SECOND PLAYBOOK PRIMER

EU leaders will later this week discuss the One Europe, One Market roadmap … but what's that? It's a plan intended to revamp the single market to boost the bloc's competitiveness (drawing on the recommendations of former Italian Prime Minister Mario Draghi). The plan aims to complete a revamp of everything, from the rules on founding companies to public procurement, by the end of 2027.

TALK TO PLAYBOOK: WhatsApp us on +32 491 050629 and listen from 7 a.m. to hear if we give you a shout-out.

FRANCE'S EU BUDGET FIX

LET GOOGLE PAY: France's Europe Minister Benjamin Haddad will push Brussels to use a €4.6 billion EU fine imposed on Google to fund the bloc's budget and reduce national contributions to Brussels, Gregorio Sorgi reports.

"The real debate is whether the European Commission will use this revenue to fund additional spending or take the opportunity to reduce member countries' contributions," Haddad told reporters. He will raise this issue, first reported by POLITICO in July, with EU Budget Commissioner Piotr Serafin in Paris tomorrow.

France is also championing new EU levies, known as own resources, to finance the bloc's seven-year money pot (from 2028 to 2034) and reduce national contributions.

In a message to more reluctant EU governments, Haddad said this on own resources: "We need to go further and also bring the European Parliament's proposals into the discussion." These include taxes on U.S. digital giants, online gambling and crypto firms, which were left out of the latest budget negotiating figures presented on Saturday .

France as kingmaker? Haddad was invited to a dinner of the "Friends of Cohesion" group calling for a larger budget on Monday evening, according to an adviser. This morning, he'll join a breakfast for the

so-called “modernizer” faction — otherwise known as the frugals.

European Council appetizer: European affairs ministers will weigh in on the new figures at a meeting in Luxembourg today.

Ready to talk: Spain issued a statement after the Friends of Cohesion dinner, saying those present were ready to “engage constructively in discussions on the revenue side of the union’s budget, with a view to relieving the direct pressure on national budgets.”

But the Friends of Cohesion also expressed “regret” over the Irish presidency’s proposed cuts. On the issue of own resources, the statement said the meeting highlighted the need for “new genuine, fair, simple and non-regressive own resources,” including a “more gradual repayment of NextGenerationEU” — the temporary post Covid-19 recovery package.

3 MORE THINGS GETTING US TALKING

HIT THE BRAKE: The leaders of Germany, Italy and Belgium have written to European Council President António Costa calling for EU capitals to be able to block legislation if they think it’s too burdensome for governments and businesses.

AI PITCH: Ursula von der Leyen pitched using artificial intelligence to streamline administrative procedures for European businesses as part of a broader push to simplify commerce and boost the EU’s competitiveness, Gerardo Fortuna reports.

RACE AGAINST TIME: French presidential contender Raphaël Glucksmann won the Socialist primary decisively but now faces a hard slog to draw supporters away from both the far left’s Jean-Luc Mélenchon and the splintered center.

BRUSSELS CORNER

WEATHER: Cloudy, with afternoon showers and a top temperature of 20C.

THE REAL EUROPEAN SUMMIT: The bubble is bracing for the biggest European gathering of the week … and no, it’s not EUCO. The Brussels Oktoberfest has secured the registration of 13 commissioners, including Magnus Brunner, Christophe Hansen and Teresa Ribera, according to one EU official, while Bavarian Minister-President Markus Söder is also expected at the opening.

Beer politics: For the uninitiated, this is the place to lobby the German-speaking crowd or have a word with some of the most powerful people in town, like European Parliament President Roberta Metsola. Which explains the broad appeal. One EU official put it simply to Playbook: “You know the [German] saying that politics is made in the beer tent?”

Timing is everything: Oktoberfest runs from Wednesday through Oct. 24. So, when should you go? “You need to go on Wednesday, man,” a second EU official told Gerardo, who was trying to plan his visit. That’s when the big names are expected, despite some rushing back from the EPP Study Days in Taormina, others juggling Regions Week and everyone else preparing for EUCO.

SOLD OUT: Friday’s hottest ticket isn’t the EU summit either — although the scramble for journalists’ seats has been unusually fierce. It’s Angèle’s free “Instinct” album-release party at the Grand-Place at 6:30 p.m. Registration is already full … but at least you can still listen to the album.

STRANGERS IN TOWN: Noticed unfamiliar faces around the EU district? The European Week of Regions and Cities has attracted to Brussels nearly 5,000 participants, including some 150 journalists. Committee of the Regions President Kata Tüttő delivered the "State of the Regions" yesterday; expect more spirited defenses of regional funding in coming days.

WOMEN TAKE THE SCREEN: The Brussels International Women's Film Festival opens today at UGC De Brouckère, with the Brussels premiere of "Marie Madeleine" by Haitian director Gessica Généus, screened in the spectacular Grand Eldorado. More than 40 films by women filmmakers are on the menu, through Oct. 18.

TOP OF THE PLAYBOOKS

Berlin: Friedrich Merz is expected to press ahead with his welfare reforms after his labor minister quit yesterday — but Bärbel Bas' shock resignation could be a watershed for the fraught coalition.

Paris: Raphaël Glucksmann is eager to rally the anti-Mélenchon left behind his presidential bid, but that's hardly a sure thing after a bruising primary.

Madrid: King Felipe VI arrives in Ceuta today , after a week-long operation to clear the beaches that has left the city looking better than at any point since the crisis began.

London: Andy Burnham is indulging in a spot of speed dating with top business leaders as he tries to sell his vision for a closer relationship with Europe .

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AGENDA

— The General Affairs Council meets in Luxembourg to debate the EU's 2028–2034 budget and prepare for this week's European Council summit. Press conference around 4:15 p.m. Watch live .

— EU accession conference with Albania in Luxembourg, provisionally closing Chapter 20 on enterprise and industrial policy. Press conference with Enlargement Commissioner Marta Kos and Albania's Prime Minister Edi Rama at 5:50 p.m. Watch live .

— EU accession conference with Ukraine in Luxembourg, opening negotiations on the internal market and competitiveness clusters. Press conference with Kos and Ukraine's Deputy Prime Minister for European and Euro-Atlantic Integration Vsevolod Chentsov at 7:20 p.m. Watch live .

— EU accession conference with Moldova in Luxembourg, opening negotiations on the internal market and competitiveness clusters. Press conference with Kos and Moldova's Deputy Prime Minister for European Integration Cristina Gherasimov at 8:50 p.m. Watch live .

— The Warsaw Security Forum continues in Poland, with speakers including the foreign ministers of Estonia, Germany, Lithuania, Norway, Poland, Romania, Spain, the U.K. and Ukraine.

— EU High Representative Kaja Kallas meets Germany's Foreign Minister Johann Wadephul in Berlin.

— Defense Commissioner Andrius Kubilius is in Warsaw, where he meets Poland's Defense Minister Władysław Kosiniak-Kamysz and Foreign Minister Radosław Sikorski. Press conference with

Kosiniak-Kamysz at 10:25 a.m. Watch live .

— Trade Commissioner Maroš Šefčovič chairs the high-level EU-Turkey trade dialogue.

— European Parliament President Roberta Metsola addresses the European People's Party Group Study Days in Taormina, Italy, at 9:30 a.m.

— Informal meeting of EU telecommunications ministers in Limerick, Ireland. Press conference at 3:30 p.m.

— European Week of Regions and Cities continues in Brussels. Commission Executive Vice President Raffaele Fitto takes part in a session on "Making the Right to Stay a Reality" at 8:45 a.m. Watch live .

— European Committee of the Regions plenary in Brussels from 3 p.m. Commission Executive Vice President Roxana Mînzatu will give an address on the joint action plan on renewed cooperation on employment and social policies at 3:50 p.m. Watch live .

— Economy Commissioner Valdis Dombrovskis is in Bangkok, Thailand, for the World Bank Group and IMF annual meeting. He'll meet Saudi Arabia's Finance Minister Mohammed Al-Jadaan.

— Crisis Management Commissioner Hadja Lahbib opens the EU-Latin America and Caribbean high-level dialogue on disaster risk management in Brussels at 2:35 p.m. Watch live .

— International Partnerships Commissioner Jozef Síkela is in Kuala Lumpur for the EU-Malaysia Business Forum.

BIRTHDAYS

Former MEP Lance Forman; European Commission's Lina Cuccovia; Greek pop star and politician Nana Mouskouri; Luc Van den Brande, former president of the Committee of the Regions; European Parliament's Monika Strasser.

Playbook is brought to you by POLITICO's EU Politics team: Gerardo Fortuna, Nicholas Vinocur, Gabriel Gavin, Zoya Sheftalovich, Max Griera, Mari Eccles, Hanne Cokelaere and Sebastian Starcevic. And: reporters Milena Wälde and Daria Zakharova, editors Alex Spence and James Panichi, and producers Dean Southwell and Hugh Kapernaros.

POLITICAL ADVERTISEMENT

**A message from EFPIA: The value of investing in innovative medicines extends far beyond the health system. Better population health can mean fewer days in hospital, more people able to work and contribute to society, and less pressure on families and carers. Between 2014 and 2022, new medicines contributed to 1.83 million fewer years of life lost before age 85 and 20.9 million fewer hospital days, equivalent to freeing up more than 57,000 hospital beds for a full year. Reducing spending may appear attractive in the short term. However, if it discourages innovation, delays access or weakens investment, today's savings can quickly become tomorrow's costs, that reappear elsewhere. They can mean worse outcomes for patients, lower productivity and slower growth - impacting families, workplaces and the economy. Europe's health and economic ambitions go hand in hand. A regular high-level dialogue between EU institutions, Member States and leaders from the research-based pharmaceutical industry and relevant stakeholders could help build a shared understanding of what Europe needs to retain and attract research, innovation and manufacturing, identify where further

progress is needed and maintain momentum on implementation.**

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